

Lifestyles

Section
B

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Raptor center: A haven for nature's winged hunters



Photo by Mitze Bender



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Folks gathered around to listen to Keith Parker's presentation on albinism during one of CRC's special weekend programs.

sky was the limit for CRC. As the facility grew, the staff worked diligently to create educational programs for the public. Now CRC offers both on-site and off-site educational programs and will travel as far as 400 miles to teach others about raptors.

"What makes these birds raptors?" CRC volunteer Kendis Parker asked spectators at the Center. She explained the term "raptor" comes from the Latin word meaning "to seize and carry away."

"You can tell by their hooked or curved beaks and their feet; see those sharp talons," Parker

"Some of the birds are non-releasable, meaning the bird is unable to survive in the wild," explains Mills. Some of these permanently-disabled raptors can be seen on the nature trail; others become part of CRC's educational programs.

So far this year, CRC has housed 472 birds, 141 of which were released into the wild. Before a raptor is released, it spends some time in a large flight cage, where the bird is encouraged to fly and build up its flight muscles. An attempt is made to release the bird near the location where it was found, if possible.

owls breeding in North America. The most common causes of injury to these predators are being struck by a vehicle or being shot.

Parker said in 1993 two Golden Eagles were stolen from the Center and sold.

"There is a black market for this sort of thing ... but it is illegal to have even a feather or the nest of a bird of prey," warned Parker during one of the Center's special weekend programs.

The programs are presented at 12:30, 2 and 3 p.m. on Saturdays and Sundays and cover a variety of topics.

Sigmond, a red-tailed female hawk, was treated at the Carolina Raptor Center following a gun shot wound. The wound left her permanently disabled, so she is now a resident at the Center.

BY MITZE BENDER

Huntersville's Carolina Raptor Center, home to more than 100 raptors, was established in 1980 by Dr. Richard Brown, an ornithologist at the University of North Carolina in Charlotte, and one of his students, Deb Sue Griffin.

In September 1975 an injured broad-winged hawk was brought to Dr. Brown, and, with the help of his students, the hawk was rehabilitated and released later that year. Over the next four years nearly a dozen birds were brought to the university, and Brown and Griffin realized the need for an organization to rehabilitate these injured raptors. Thus, the Carolina Raptor Center (CRC) was hatched.

In 1981, CRC was incorporated as a non-profit corporation, and a board of directors was established. At first, the organization operated from several rooms in the biology department at UNCC, where an all-volunteer staff cared for the birds, but it wasn't

long before they outgrew the rooms, admitting as many as 218 patients by 1984.

That same year the Mecklenburg County Parks and Recreation Department offered to lease CRC 57 acres at Latta Plantation on Mountain Island Lake. In the beginning, their facility was a small shed, with no power, water or phone service. Water for the raptors had to be hauled in buckets from the lake. Later two mobile homes were installed, and volunteers constructed exercise cages for injured birds and housing for non-releasable raptors.

In 1986, CRC received a grant from Mecklenburg County, and a small staff was organized. Pat Marcum, the center's second executive director, was instrumental in developing the facility into a top attraction for visitors. Over the next few years, volunteers built permanent cages along the mile-long nature trail with more than 20 species of raptors on display to the public.

From that point forward, the

points out to me. I've seen young birds, they use these to tear meat from the bone."

CRC currently has seven educational programs, but many others are being developed.

"We are in the developmental phase of creating a multitude of other programs that align with the state curriculum," said Michelle Mills, director of education for CRC. "We are creating programs that meet other state objectives and goals, not just science ... like literacy objectives, art objectives and so forth."

Mills said CRC has an art program that allows students to use the raptors as live models, and another program developed with Bruns Avenue Elementary for their environmental science core curriculum in which radio "backpacks" are attached to Osprey. Students use the information to study longitude and latitude and to track the eagle's speed and vector.

Birds admitted to the Carolina Raptor Center are immediately examined and treated before they begin rehabilitation. Once rehabilitated, the birds are released. Unfortunately, some of the raptors must remain in captivity.

and appropriate. According to the CRC web site (www.birdsofprey.org), there are 33 species of hawks, falcons, vultures and eagles and 18 species of

A few weeks ago, Keith Parker talked to spectators about albinism.

See RAPTOR CENTER Page 2B



Photo by Travis Coriher

Each weekend, Carolina Raptor Center presents a new educational program at 12:30, 2 and 3 p.m. on Saturdays and Sundays.



Photo by Mitze Bender

Honeysuckle is an albino hawk who became part of the Center's educational programs when she was injured.

RAPTOR CENTER

28 - DAVIDSON GAZETTE - Thursday, September 13, 2001